

When Amma announced ₹100 crore for tsunami relief, many wondered how a small ashram could afford such a commitment. The relief and rehabilitation work would eventually exceed ₹500 crore. Yet the deepest measure of that response lies in the attention given to the smallest human needs.

Whatever Amma does carries a deeply personal care. Her attention reaches into the quiet details of people's lives, where an easily overlooked need can mean everything to the person living with it.

Her response to the 2004 tsunami reveals this beautifully. Amid the immense work of rescue and rebuilding, she noticed the lost spectacles, the child afraid of water, the elderly person who needed a different meal. Thousands needed help. Each needed to be understood.

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EVERYONE SAW A DISASTER.
AMMA SAW PEOPLE.

She saw the sea pull back and knew what it meant. Forty five minutes later, three thousand people were standing on higher floors.

She saw families scattered by the wave and helped them find each other to cross the backwaters. They went together or they waited together.

She saw people standing in wet clothes and sent for milk, tea powder and sugar before anything else. Hot tea gave an immediate sense of comfort.

She saw the four hundred villagers whose spectacles the wave had taken, who now needed a hand just to cross a room. Twenty eye camps. Four hundred pairs of glasses free of cost.

She saw that prescription medications lay buried in the flooded houses, and sent volunteers to search the mud for the patients who had nothing.

She saw empty pockets, and had three crore rupees drawn from the bank. Cash was placed in every hand, with no document asked for, because the documents were gone too.

She saw that the elderly could not digest chapati at night, and made kanji the dinner. Every night. For five months.

She saw that a fishing village misses the taste of fish, and had the lunch curry made to carry that taste, from vegetables and spice alone.

She saw brides whose wedding gold was gone and whose wedding day was four days away, and held the weddings on the same chosen date, inside the relief camp.

She saw children who could not say what had happened to them, and asked them to draw instead. The waves came back on every page.

She saw children who could no longer look at the sea, and walked into the water with them to teach them to swim.

She saw that coming home to filth would break families a second time, and had every surviving house cleaned before they walked back in. The walls, the floors, the clothes, the vessels, the toilets.

She saw that a house without a staircase leaves a child with nowhere to run, and put sixty square feet of stairway to the terrace into every home she built.

She saw hamlets reachable only by boat where all the homes were lost. Others had quietly left them out because the cost per house was too high. She built free homes there too.

She saw that a village with one bridge is a trap, and built a second one at the exact midpoint of the island, so that no family was further from safety than any other.

She saw that the families who ferried people across would lose their living the day her bridge opened, and paid them until they found other work.

She saw families who lost all their children with mothers who had long ago been sterilised. She found the specialists, arranged the reversal surgeries, had the medicines flown in from Switzerland, and carried every cost until the babies were born. All six mothers became parents again. Three of them had twins.